

Keep Talking

The stuff that keeps us going on and on and on

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From its none too humble days as a 40 kg car add-on to its current barely-there form, the cellular phone has become as much as a part of our lives as a pair of shoes. Twelve years ago, cellular networks were set up in the four metros, and you'd pay Rs 8 per minute for your calls, and Rs 16 during peak hours. You'd make these calls on handsets that we now so affectionately call the "pencil-box" phones. Ah, good times.

Today, the cell phone has become the ultimate convergence device. Play games, listen to music, take photos, record movies, view documents, surf the Net and make phone calls too!

Into the Arcade

If you remember *Snake*, raise your hands. It was (and still is to some) one of the best things you could do with your phone, and sent the concept of mobile gaming on a wild toboggan ride that's still going. Newer phones came with support for Java and colour screens, enabling wilder, richer games right there in your pocket.

The Sony Ericsson W550i

While it came out as another one in Sony Ericsson's line of Walkman phones, no phone has been as conducive to gaming - not even the pioneer, the Nokia N-Gage QD - as the SE W550i. Turn it horizontally and you have a clear, crisp TFT screen in landscape mode and a button arrangement almost like a dedicated game controller. Its fast processor lets you play 3D games with ease, and the bundled Worms Forts game is extremely addictive, especially with the ability to

throw stuff like refrigerators and banana bombs at your opponent.

Getting Down To Business

The days of the PDA are numbered. With smart phones getting ever smarter, we now have cell phones that are veritable powerhouses for the businessman on the go. They have all the necessary features of the PDA - powerful organisers, synchronising contacts and data with your home PC, and all the abilities of a phone on top of that! With a GPRS or EDGE connection, you can now connect your PDA-Phone to the Internet; the world is your office!

The Sony Ericsson P990i

Pick up your jaws; the Sony Ericsson P990i takes mixing business with pleasure to new levels. Running on the Symbian 9.1 operating system and UIQ 3 platform, the phone comes packed with a host of business and entertainment applications. It's capable of holding up to 4 GB of data (or music, or video, if you'd like), and also features Word and Excel editors, and viewers for PowerPoint presentations and PDF files. The flip-lid sports a standard phone keypad on one side; open it, and you reveal a full-fledged QWERTY keyboard on the underside.

Another nifty feature is that its 2 Megapixel camera also moonlights as a business card scanner, using character recognition to convert the scanned card into text! It's even Wi-Fi enabled so you can connect to the Internet the way you choose - WLAN or GPRS.

Freedom with VoIP

There has been much talk about VoIP (Voice over IP) for a long time. When the concept first hit